

you whether to remain Good or go to the Bad.

There are no long-range weapons in this game, only melee weapons like swords, maces and battle axes. You can throw weapons at enemies from afar, and also throw severed limbs and chopped off heads—whoopee!

In fact, the game is more suited for single-player mode because of the nature of the weapons—it's kind of boring to spar for a long time with a human player unless you're an expert at fencing!

And then there's the usual idea: the more levels you complete, the more skill and strength you acquire, which unlocks more weapons. *Rune* is based on the *Unreal Tournament* engine, enhanced for spiffy graphics like shadow effects and natural outdoor environments.

Rune and its subsequent titles are property of Human Head Studios. Released in 2000, it retails at just \$11 (about Rs 500).

Rating: 8/10

Neverwinter Nights

<http://nwn.bioware.com>

An expansive game with an epic storyline, *Neverwinter Nights* has been a long-time favourite of fantasy RPG gamers. It is based on the rules of *Dungeons and Dragons* and the original NWN MMORPG, which was the first graphical game in its genre.

As in other such games, you select characters from different races—a Barbarian, a Rogue, a Wizard, a Paladin. The characters can be customised to a large extent: you can assign specific skill sets, for example. The main aims in NWN are (a) to find a cure for a plague that's decimating the population of Neverwinter City by collecting "reagents" from different sources, and also (b) to defend the city.

The gameplay is not linear: you have a choice in many scenarios, and your choice determines the outcome of many side-plots. An interesting number of twists and turns will keep you entertained throughout the game—a thoroughly addictive experience, we'd say.

The Windows version of the game ships with the Aurora tool kit, which enables custom content creation in both single-player and multiplayer modes. Another feature that sets this game apart from other RPG games is that as your levels advance, you get to become a jack-of-all-trades instead of becoming a specialist. In a world where you have to fight diverse enemies, this is pretty cool; in fact, it's a lifesaver.

NWN was released by Bioware in 2002 to 2003 across different platforms, and retails at \$14.99 (Rs 625). The Linux client is available for free at the homepage.

Rating: 8/10



Lady Aribeth de Tylmarande, a central character

Ragnarok

<http://iro.ragnarokonline.com>

Ragnarok is a fantasy MMORPG mainly based on Norse mythology (we told you game developers love Vikings), where you inhabit a vast fantasy world, fight battles, marry, trade, and go on with the business of life. But mainly fight.

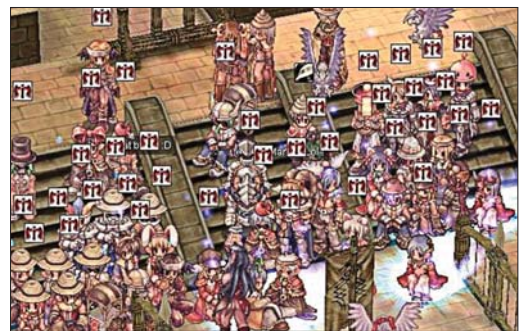
First things first: to play *Ragnarok*, you need a decent Internet connection—by that we mean at least a sustained 256 Kbps. Otherwise you'll be pretty much staring at your screen most of the time. You also need to pay to play—depending on the payment scheme, it works out to about \$10 (Rs 400) per month.

Registration and all completed, there is a choice of four servers—you can connect to any one and start playing. Choose your character's attributes like hair colour and length, though your gender is automatically assigned (because you indicated it when you signed up at the site). As a novice, you select your job and steadily advance up the ranks. Examples of jobs are swordsman, thief,

merchant, and magician. Combat styles, quests and any in-game behaviour depend upon the job selected for yourself. If you connect to a different server, you'll have to go through the entire process all over. Players advance their character levels based on their quests and/or credit points, which they can also buy. These points let you acquire stronger weapons. There are player vs. player encounters, and also guild battles—depending on time of week and the server. The graphics are Japanese anime-style, which really does not mesh in with the Norse backdrop of the storyline. Sad—but they probably have a reason.

For a newbie, *Ragnarok*, or any other MMORPG for that matter, takes a lot of time to master. There are too many quirks and idiosyncrasies—due in large part to the fact that you're interacting with other humans here, not bots.

Rating: 7/10



A meeting in progress: notice the anime-themed characters

